



UNVEILING THE STRUGGLES: INDIGENOUS WOMEN'S POLITICAL REPRESENTATION IN ELOTA, SINALOA, MEXICO

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What are the underlying factors preventing the attainment of political representation for indigenous women in Elota, Sinaloa?

INTRODUCTION

The 1953 Convention on the Political Rights of Women set the stage for global recognition and protection of women's political rights. It declared that women can hold public positions and perform public duties on equal terms with men, free from discrimination as mandated by national laws.

Although Mexico's Political Constitution recognizes its multicultural and multiethnic composition, it fails to protect indigenous women's voting and candidacy rights fully.

Our study examines the political representation of indigenous women in Elota, Sinaloa, Mexico. We aim to promote gender equality and highlight their challenges in pursuing representation and political engagement at the municipal level.

JUSTIFICATION

This study examines the challenges indigenous women face in Elota, Sinaloa, in pursuing political representation at the municipal level. Our research emphasizes the need for greater awareness among indigenous women about their political and electoral rights.

The broader context highlights the influence of various factors that deter ethnic groups from participating in public life within the federative entity. As we embark on this journey, it is important to note the scarcity of research addressing this specific topic at the municipal level in Sinaloa, underscoring the crucial significance of our research project.

PILOT STUDY RESULTS

THE FOLLOWING ARE RECURRING THEMES THAT WERE IDENTIFIED IN THE INTERVIEWS:

Theme 1: Lack of Political Participation

- ▶ Indigenous women in Elota have minimal political representation.
- ▶ No indigenous woman has ever been popularly elected, resulting in a lack of legal initiatives, projects, or programs that cater to this demographic's specific challenges.

Theme 2: Obstacles to Political Representation

- ▶ While initial efforts have been made to ensure political representation for indigenous women in electoral matters, key informants Dr. Jorge López Hernandez and Dr. Gonzalo Armienta Hernandez note that some political figures exploit the right of self-election to attain public office.
- ▶ The Sinaloa state constitution should establish mechanisms to promote political participation and representation of indigenous women at the municipal level.

Theme 3: Voting Rights vs. Candidacy Rights

- ▶ According to Dr. Gonzalo Armienta Hernandez Indigenous women in Elota exercise their right to vote but are not allowed to run for office, highlighting a notable disparity.
- ▶ The four interviewees stress the importance of providing spaces for indigenous women's participation in politics, believing their involvement could instil greater confidence in the indigenous population towards their authorities.

METHODOLOGY

We use a pilot study as an initial step to explore the issues surrounding women's political representation in Elota. We selected four participants Dr. Gonzalo Armienta Hernandez, Dr. Jorge López Hernandez, Pablo Timoteo Curiel Morales y Lorena Tejeda Tejeda for in-depth interviews using a non-probabilistic sampling approach, allowing us to choose participants based on their relevant experiences and willingness to share their insights and stories in line with Otzen and Manterola (2017).

We conducted four semi-structured interviews with two researchers, a public servant, and an indigenous woman. These interviews formed the backbone of our data collection process, providing valuable perspectives and knowledge.

The analysis of the interviews involved categorizing the data based on the concepts and themes outlined in our interviews, shedding light on the factors contributing to women's lack of political representation in Elota. The legal framework for the political representation of indigenous women is the second article of the Constitutional policy of the United Mexican States: "Indigenous women and men will enjoy and exercise their right to vote and be voted for under conditions of equality."



Theme 4: The Power of Gender Perspective

- ▶ Interviewees view representativeness from a gender perspective as a means for indigenous women to express their needs and address challenges, particularly related to health and public works.
- ▶ Indigenous women face multifaceted exclusion in politics, society, and the economy.

Theme 5: Triple Challenge Faced by Indigenous Women

- ▶ Indigenous women in Elota face the triple challenge of combating gender discrimination, embracing their indigenous identity, and overcoming poverty, highlighting the complexity of their situation



Limitations:

- Small Sample Size:** Our study is based on just four interviews, a minimal sample.
- Initial Exploratory Nature:** As a pilot study, our research serves as an exploratory phase, preventing us from making sweeping generalizations.
- Lack of Quantitative Data:** We rely on qualitative data for rich insights but lack quantitative data's statistical rigour for more robust conclusions.
- Conceptual and Theoretical Framework:** Our research needs a well-defined and established conceptual and theoretical framework, which limits our ability to interpret findings within a broader context.

We need more research to understand the factors hindering political representation for indigenous women in Elota. These preliminary results emphasize the importance of expanding our investigation to address these challenges.



CONCLUSIONS

Although this pilot study provides insight into the critical themes surrounding the political representation of indigenous women in Elota, Sinaloa, it is important to recognize that this is just the beginning of a complex journey. With only four interviews conducted, we face limitations preventing us from making definitive conclusions at this stage. However, the preliminary results are a valuable starting point for further research and exploration.

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